

pieces); FIDE Master and prolific YouTube chess streamer from North America Alexandra Botez (yellow); and chess commentator and player Antonio Radic from Croatia, better known by his YouTube moniker, Agadmator, with green pieces.

Lastly, there is the commentator and host, stand-up comedian Samay Raina, who flags off the game with some sagacious advice to the players to make friends on the chess board, and then betray them or perish. As the game begins, the live stream is filled with voices of these acute chess players trying to goad and cajole each other to go after the other players' pieces.

This isn't 'serious' stuff, in the sense that this is no professional tournament. But live-streaming of chess games now attracts participants ranging from professional GMs and Woman GMs, to comedians, cricket players and even business personalities. The usually 64-squared board—sometimes it's 160 squares in four-player chess—witnesses several off-the-record, live-streamed games and tournaments.

THE GENESIS of chess streaming lies in the FIDE Online Chess Olympiad 2020 that was organised after the 44th Chess Olympiad got postponed due to the coronavirus pandemic, says Indian GM Srinath Narayanan. "The streaming started when I saw the amount of interest—70,000 people watching the final. It was incredible, the passion of the people. How willing they were to

help the team in every way possible. As soon as the Olympiad ended, I started streaming in about a week or so." Narayanan belongs to the growing tribe of Indian pro-chess players, enthusiasts and followers who cover professional tournaments, live-stream their casual games, and/or review and commentate on chess games played around the global professional chess circuit.

As more chess players have turned streamers, the game has benefitted immensely. It has started shedding its reputation of being a boring, incomprehensible mind-bender. And the audience is attracted to the live streams and recordings due to the lively banter and trash talk that usually accompanies any match-up between the very competitive top pro-chess players. The pleasure of watching them take down their opponents and explain how they are doing it is a heady combination.

Sample this: As the first pieces move across the board, GM Gujrathi pitches for an alliance and GM Giri takes him up on his offer; FIDE Master Botez chimes in with the insight that all the GMs cannot gang up against the streamers and the alliance needs to be broken. Host Raina suggests that Gujrathi is a veteran of the format, and all three of them should first team up to eliminate him.

A shocked Gujrathi disbelievingly says he cannot trust the alliance with Giri and makes a move to test his loyalty. In response, a little hurt Giri lets his Bishop be taken by Gujrathi to prove him wrong. Suddenly, the quiet but observant Agadmator butts in to say that it makes sense to go after

Gujrathi since he has an extra Queen converted from a Pawn. As Agadmator says this, Gujrathi confronts Giri on targeting his Bishop. Giri assertively replies that he is just defending his own Bishop. While the two grandmasters resolve their little kerfuffle, Botez deviously asks Agadmator if he's interested in working as a team to take on the GMs, since she senses a crack in their alliance.

The combination of shop talk and trash talk is almost irresistible. On display for the audience is every bit of nuanced calculation, permutation, combination, collaboration, co-operation, deal-making, deal-breaking and negotiation skills available in the players' arsenal, deployed by them to get the upper hand in the game.

While there is a lot to learn for an astute student of the game, the sheer entertainment factor of the streams combined with how interesting and insightful the game itself is, has made chess approachable again, says International Master (IM) and Woman GM Tania Sachdev. "There is this serious image attached to chess. But suddenly seeing chess players just have fun has made it more approachable again. People have rekindled their love for the game and I think streaming has a big role to play in that."

Srinath concurs: "I had never seen such numbers of people interested in chess. There were a lot of people interested in chess, but people who didn't know how to play chess but still wanted to watch, that was something new to see."

Even though chess is said to have originated somewhere in the Indian

As chess players have turned streamers, the game has shed its reputation of being a boring, incomprehensible, mind-bending game, due to the players' relatable lively streams